

James Robinson  
Acadia University  
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### **Teaching Philosophy**

I believe that learning is a foundational and perpetual human experience, a passion for which should be nurtured and modeled as early and as often as possible. Excitement around learning, be it general or subject-specific, is contagious and self-supportive. Therefore, I will create a classroom environment wherein small acts of exploration, discovery, and progress are recognized and celebrated. Since learning is best when constructive upon prior knowledge, students should be taught the value of incremental achievement facilitated by the delivery of curriculum in small, manageable pieces and the gradual release of responsibility from teacher to student. Students should also be empowered to recognize and reflect on their learning independently so as to develop not only the motivation but also the method of continuing their education outside of the classroom. Assessment, then, should be identified as a tool to gather information rather than an obstacle to overcome and feedback as a step forward whether it is delivered by a teacher, peer, or individual. Incorporation of formative assessment, if accompanied by clear purpose, rationale, and supports, demonstrates to students their progress and spurs on further investigation.

I believe that learning is necessarily communal and multi-directional. Strict hierarchies limit rather than expand possibilities; a teacher who purports to know everything entirely is a deficit to their students whereas a teacher who embraces the unknown opens a world of possibilities for students to explore. I seek to make my class a place where every student feels capable of making meaningful contributions to our collective understanding whether through direct discussion, collaboration with peers, or simply expressing their own unique perspective. This necessitates valuing the opportunity of mistakes, validating the thinking process, and establishing an environment of mutual respect and trust. To teach effectively, I think it should be the primary objective of teachers to build positive relationships with each of their students, making a point to learn their names, discover how they learn best, and take a genuine interest in their lived experiences. No matter the setting, people need to feel seen, heard, and understood if they are to perform at their best and adolescents especially are often searching for validation and acceptance as a primary goal.

I believe that learning is equally valuable regardless of its form and that students themselves have the greatest insight into how they learn best. I think that it is important, as a teacher, to recognize that my way of thinking is not universal nor superior to any other. Further, giving students choice and autonomy supports their learning of material and engagement with the class while also teaching them extracurricular skills and aspects of themselves that will benefit every part of their lives. I seek to create a classroom that challenges traditional notions of intelligence and the value of knowledge as utility and instead encourages students to embrace their individual ways of thinking and work towards their own goals.